There were two kinds of markets or bazaars in the leading cities like Puhar and Madurai. In Madurai they were Nalangadi (the morning market) and Allangadi (the evening market). In these markets large varieties as well as large quantities of goods were sold and purchased.

Major Ports

- Musiri, Tondi, Korkai

Main Exports

- Salt, pepper, pearls, ivory, silk, spices, diamonds, saffron, precious stones, muslin, sandal wood

Main Imports

- Topaz, tin, glass, horses

Silk supplied by Indian merchants to the Roman Empire was considered so important that the Roman emperor Aurelian declared it to be worth its weight in gold.

Muziris – First Emporium

The Roman writer Pliny the Elder writes of Muziris in his *Natural History* as the 'first emporium (shopping complex) of India'. A temple of Augustus was built at Muziris, which had a Roman colony.

A papyrus document (now in Vienna museum) of 2nd century BC (BCE) records the agreement between two merchants' shippers of Alexandria and Muziris.

Trade Contact with Overseas Countries

Archaeological excavations have confirmed the trading relations between the Tamizhagam and the countries such as Greece, Rome, Egypt, China, South East Asia and Sri Lanka.

Kalabhras

Towards the end of the 3rd century AD (CE), the Sangam period slowly went into a decline. Following the Sangam period, the Kalabhras had occupied the Tamil country for about two and half centuries. We have very little information about Kalabhras. They left neither artefacts nor monuments. But there is evidence of their rule in literary texts. The literary sources for this period include *Tamil Navalar Charithai, Yapernkalam* and *Periapuranam*. *Seevaka Chinthamani* and *Kundalakesi* were also written during this period. In Tamizhagam, Jainism and Buddhism became prominent during this period. Introduction of Sanskrit and Prakrit languages had resulted in the development of a new script called *Vattezhuththu*. Many works under *Pathinen Keezhkanakku* were composed. Trade and commerce continued to flourish during this period. So the Kalabhra period is not a dark age, as it is portrayed.

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